

LUCÍA CONTRERAS

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Microeconomics | Public Finance | Applied Econometrics

EDUCATION

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| 2025 (expected) | Ph.D. Economics, University of Manchester , Manchester, UK |
| 2018 | M.Sc. Economics (Distinction), University of Sussex , Brighton, UK |
| 2014 | B.Sc. Economics, University of Costa Rica , San José, Costa Rica |

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Researcher

May 2019-Aug 2021

Institute for Research in Economic Sciences (IICE), University of Costa Rica

Main projects:

- Methodological Proposal and Road Map to Measure the Public Expenditure on Children, funded by UNICEF
Coordinated the project, developed the methodology, supervised four research assistants, delivered workshops, presented the results to policy makers and UNICEF officials, had administrative responsibilities, and was in charge of communication with the public institutions and with UNICEF.
- Estimation of the Effects of Approving the Bill for the Management and Regularisation of the State's Natural Patrimony and the Provision of Environmental Utility Rights (land use rights)- DUA Law, funded by UNDP
Coordinated the project, worked with georeferenced geographic and census data, performed statistical analysis to compare potential beneficiary areas with controls, and presented at a commission of the Costa Rican Congress.
- Impacts of the Tax Reform on the Costa Rican Labour Market, funded by UCR
Conducted literature reviews, performed descriptive statistical analysis using survey labour data, and wrote reports about the dynamics of informality, social security, participation, unemployment, gender and education.
- Economic Impact of a Tax on Plastics, funded by UNDP.
Conducted the literature review, participated in analysing the effects of the tax on households and economic activity, and collaborated in writing the report presented at a commission of the Costa Rican Congress.

Consultant

Mar 2019-Jul 2021

Tropical Agricultural Research and Higher Education Center (CATIE)

Projects:

- Adaptation Mechanisms Against Negative Effects of Weather on Human Capital Formation, funded by Efd.
Performed statistical and econometrical analysis using georeferenced climate and school data in Costa Rica, carried out paper presentations, and collaborated in writing the paper on precipitation shocks and school dropout.
- Adaptation to Climate Change of Rural Water Provider Organisations in Central America, funded by IDRC/CRDI.
Managed the project's data base (household and rural water providers survey for dry areas in Nicaragua, Guatemala and Costa Rica), conducted statistical and econometric analysis of the determinants of water use in dry areas.

Researcher

Aug 2016-Aug 2017

Development Observatory (OdD), University of Costa Rica

Project:

- Perspectives for Wind Energy in Costa Rica, funded by UCR.
Developed the research proposal, conducted literature reviews, analysed the evolution and public policies regarding electricity and wind energy, interviewed experts, and wrote the report.

Research Assistant

Nov 2014-Jul 2016

Tropical Agricultural Research and Higher Education Center (CATIE)

Project:

- Ecosystem-Based Adaptation for Smallholder Farmers in Central America (CASCADE), funded by IKI.
Managed the project's data base (household survey of small farmers in Honduras, Guatemala and Costa Rica), performed statistical and econometric analysis and collaborated in writing technical reports and papers on adaptation to climate change and food security.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

School of Economics, University of Costa Rica

Postgraduate level	Research Methods (lecturer)	Aug 2019-Jul 2021
Undergraduate level	Introduction to Economics (lecturer)	Mar-Jul 2017
Undergraduate level assistant	Introduction to Economics (taught exercise classes)	Mar-Dec 2012

Department of Economics, University of Sussex

Undergraduate level tutor	Economic Principles (taught seminar classes)	Sep 2018-Jan 2019
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OTHER PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Economic Analyst

Mar 2013-Nov 2014

Ecoanálisis Economic and Financial Consultants

Analysed macroeconomic news and indicators, organised policy seminars.

RESEARCH PAPERS

Publication

Viguera, B.; Alpízar, F.; Harvey, C.; Martínez-Rodríguez, R.; Saborío-Rodríguez, M.; **Contreras, L.** (2019). Climate change perceptions and adaptive responses of small-scale farmers in two Guatemalan landscapes. *Agronomía Centroamericana*, 30 (2).

Work in progress

“Gone with the rain: Effects of abnormal precipitation on school dropout rate”, with Laura Villalobos and Juan Robalino. Paper accepted for the 2020 EfD Initiative Annual Meeting, and for the 2021 AERE sessions at the WEAI Conference.

“Is there an earnings gap between informal and formal employees? Evidence from Peru”. To be submitted to the *Revista de Ciencias Económicas*.

TECHNICAL REPORTS

Contreras, L.; Robalino, J.; Oviedo, L. (2020). Desarrollo de una propuesta metodológica y de una hoja de ruta para la medición de los recursos destinados a la niñez y adolescencia en Costa Rica: principales resultados del proyecto (*In English: Development of a methodological proposal and a road map to measure public expenditure on children and adolescents in Costa Rica: main results of the project*). Available here.

Robalino, J.; **Contreras, L.**; Lucke, R.; Oviedo, L. (2019). Impacto económico del impuesto al plástico (*In English: Economic impact of a tax on plastics*). Available here.

Contreras, L.; Sauma, P. (2017). Perspectivas de la energía eólica en Costa Rica: estado, retos y oportunidades (*In English: Perspectives for wind energy in Costa Rica: current status, challenges and opportunities*). Available here.

PRESENTATIONS

- **Economic study of the bill for the management and regularisation of the State’s Natural Patrimony and the Provision of Environmental Utility Rights -DUA Law** (title translated from Spanish). Presentation in front of the Special Commission of coastal and border zones that occupy public lands in a situation of conflict. Costa Rican Congress. Virtual Presentation. July 2021.
- **Effects of precipitation anomalies on school dropout rates.** Fourteenth Annual Meeting of the Environment for Development Initiative. University of Gothenburg. Virtual Conference. November 2020.
- **Effects of precipitation anomalies on school dropout rates.** School of Economics Research Seminar. University of Costa Rica. Virtual Seminar. September 2020.
- **Methodological proposal to measure public expenditure on children** (title translated from Spanish). Presentation in front of State Ministers and representatives of the National Council for Children and Adolescents. Presidential House of the Republic of Costa Rica, San José, Costa Rica. November 2019.
- **Socioeconomic context and preliminary results from the household survey.** Third Annual Meeting of the CASCADE Project. Tropical Agricultural Research and Higher Education Center (CATIE), Turrialba, Costa Rica. November 2015.

AWARDS, GRANTS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Economics PhD Studentships , University of Manchester	<i>2021-2025</i>
Mentorship Support Fund , University of Costa Rica Grant aimed at junior researchers to strengthen their research capacities, with the support of a mentor	<i>2020</i>
Chevening Scholarship , British Foreign and Commonwealth Office UK Government's fully funded Master's scholarship for outstanding international professionals	<i>2017</i>
Academic Development Programme , School of Economics, University of Costa Rica Programme supporting young talented Economists wishing to progress into postgraduate studies abroad	<i>2016</i>
Teaching Assistantship Scholarship , University of Costa Rica	<i>2012</i>
Academic Excellence Scholarship , University of Costa Rica	<i>2010</i>
Among the 20 Best Admission Test Results , University of Costa Rica 18th place among 31 000 applicants country wide	<i>2009</i>

OTHER SKILLS

Programming Languages and Frameworks: Stata, R, Matlab, ArcGis, QGis, L^AT_EX

Languages: Spanish (native), English (fluent), French (fluent)